

New Frontiers: The Staff You Never Knew You Had

Ryan O'Connor with Claude

Days ago, I asked Claude to build a dashboard. Not a casual request - it needed to pull structured data from a NetSuite Excel export and reconcile it against a patchwork of screenshots and PDF data from an in-house agency tracker. Different formats, different sources, different logic. A real data problem. It was done in hours.

That sounds unremarkable until you sit with what it actually means. That tool would never have been built before - not three years ago, not last year. The cost-benefit math never penciled out. You'd need a skilled developer who could conceive the architecture, wrangle the data formats, and build something usable. That expertise exists, and it flows toward the highest bidder - Google, Anthropic, a well-funded startup. A small agency's internal reporting tool was never going to compete for that attention. So the tool never existed, and we made do.

This is the frontier nobody's talking about loudly enough.

* * *

Here's the metaphor I want you to sit with.

Imagine you hired the smartest, most capable staff you've ever encountered. A world-class coder. A creative director with the eye of someone who's run brand for a decade. A financial analyst. A strategist. An editor. A researcher who never gets tired. They're all in the building. All available. Right now.

They won't make happy hour. They won't chime in on Slack culture. But they will answer every question, push back on every assumption, pressure-test every idea, draft every first version, and flag everything you missed - in seconds. Not tomorrow. Not after a meeting. Now.

That's what's sitting in the browser tab most people use to check spelling.

* * *

Most of the AI conversation orbits displacement - which jobs disappear, which industries get disrupted. That's real and worth examining. But there's a parallel story, and it's more important for most of us right now: for the first time, the constraint isn't talent. It's imagination.

The best creative director wasn't advising the local HVAC company on their brand voice. The best financial mind wasn't helping the family-owned restaurant understand their margins. That expertise existed, but it was rationed - by cost, by geography, by the simple physics of scarcity. Elite skill flows toward the highest bidder. Everyone else made do.

AI breaks that rationing. The plumbing company in a mid-size city can now have communications that reflect genuine creative intelligence. The regional retailer can have data analysis a Fortune 500 would recognize. The first-generation entrepreneur can think through a market entry using frameworks that used to require an MBA and a consulting engagement to access. Not a watered-down version. Something actually good.

This is democratization in the truest sense.

Before the printing press, books existed. Scribes were skilled. The knowledge was real. But it was rationed by the cost and time required to reproduce it. The press didn't eliminate scribes so much as it made their output universal - what was reserved for monasteries and kings ended up in the hands of farmers, students, and anyone willing to read. We're watching something structurally similar happen to expertise itself.

* * *

Here's where I'll be direct about something I've watched happen in my own company.

I've done the lunch-and-learns. I've sat one-on-one with people and walked through the tools. I've watched the moment of recognition cross their faces - the "oh, this could change everything" look. And then, reliably, they go back to their inbox. 600 unread emails. Slow responses. Overwhelm managed by habit.

They use AI as a slightly better Google. Formula help in Excel. Spell check with extra steps. A place to ask questions they'd otherwise search for.

That's not a staff. That's a calculator.

The bottleneck in most organizations right now isn't AI capability. The models are extraordinary. The bottleneck is the mental model people bring to them - still thinking in terms of tools and tasks, rather than advisors and thought partners. Still treating the dashboard as the exception rather than the reflex.

The people who figure this out first aren't necessarily the most technical or the most senior. They're the ones willing to change the relationship - to stop asking AI to help them do what they were already doing and start asking it what they should be doing differently.

* * *

Days ago I built something that would have taken months to justify and never gotten built. That's the frontier. Not someday, not theoretical, not a trend to monitor.

The staff is already hired. The question is whether you're going to use them.